

Session 15: The Problem of the Human Alone

Key Takeaways

- The first thing God declares as “not good” is the solitary human. The human in isolation is not God’s ideal expressed in Genesis 1.
- When the diversity of humanity unites in Christ, we more fully reflect the image of God in this world.

Lone Human is Now Two: Translation and Literary Design: Genesis 2:18-25

Problem: A Lone Human and No Help-Counterpart

18a and Yahweh God said,

"It is not good for **the human** to be **alone (לִבְדּוּ)**

18b I will make a **help-counterpart for him**

Yahweh Acts

A

19a **and Yahweh** **formed** from the ground

every living creature of the field

and every bird of the skies

Animals Brought But No Counterpart

B

19b **and he brought them to the human** to see what he would **call it**,
and everything which the human would **call it** a living being,
that was its name."

Human Names

A'

20a and the human **called** the names

of every **beast**

and bird of the skies

and every living creature of the field

Problem Not Solved: No Help-Counterpart

20b **but for the human there was not found a help-counterpart**

Yahweh Acts

A 21 and Yahweh caused to fall a deep sleep on the human and he slept
and he took one from his sides
and he closed the **flesh** of its place

Woman Brought And Counterpart!

B 22 and Yahweh **built** the side which he took from the human into **woman** ,
and he brought her to the human

Human Names

A' 23 and the human said
This time, bone from my bones, and **flesh** from my **flesh** .
This one will be **called** (יקרא) **woman** for from **man** this one was taken

Problem Solved: Lone Human is Now Two

24 For this reason,
a **man** will leave his father and his mother,
and he will cling to his **woman** ,
and they will become **one flesh** .
25a and the **two of them** were naked,
25b **the human** and his **woman** ,
and they were not ashamed."

Genesis 2:18-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Macro Design Observations: From Alone to One Flesh

This two-step divine provision of the “help” (עזר) is crucial. It mimics Genesis 1 (days 1-3 are step one, days 4-6 are step two), and it creates a model or expectation.

God is the first one to notice “no good” in his creation (Gen. 2:18). The lone human is unable to fulfill his vocation without an other.

The narrative design of Genesis 2:18-25 goes from problem to solution. A solitary human cannot accomplish the calling placed upon “the image-statue of Elohim” in Genesis 1:26-28 to rule creation as God’s partners, to image God through gender difference, and to be fruitful and multiply.

To fulfill this task, the human family must simultaneously become “many” and “one/unified,” and they must do all of this as an image of God.

Genesis 2:24 NASB*

For this reason a man shall leave his father and his mother, and cling to his wife; and they shall become one flesh.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 2:24 addresses a foundational question about human relationships: Why would a person leave their closest biological relationship (a child to their parent) and join themselves to one who is not in their family? The claim of Genesis 2:24 is that marriage overcomes this biological divide and recovers an original, unified state of humanity. The woman is not a “helper” or simply a mating partner in Genesis 2. She is half of him and he is half of her; only together can they become the unified humanity that God has called us to be.

The “one flesh” of Genesis 2:24 transcends the union of the sexual act (though it is one way the “one flesh” unity may be experienced). It is a prime example of how two humans who are genuine others to one another may experience unity and oneness.

Notice the highly surprising roles of man and woman in Genesis 2:24. It is the man who leaves his family to join a biological stranger, his wife, to create a new family. This formulation is the opposite of every marriage in the Hebrew Bible, where the woman leaves her family to join the man (e.g. Rebekah, Rachel and Leah, etc.).

The words “abandon” (*‘azab* / עָזַב) and “cling” (*dabaq* / דָּבַק) are covenantal terms that speak to the forsaking of previous bonds and “clinging” to one’s covenant partner (Deut. 4:4; 10:20; 11:22; 22:16).

The Fractured Ideal in Genesis 1-11

Genesis 1-11 will go on to explore the fracturing of this ideal unity on all levels of the human family, setting up the reader’s expectation that God will again solve this “no good” situation of a humanity unable to do what God has called them to do.

- Genesis 2-3: Fracturing the unity between a man and a woman (marriage)
- Genesis 4:1-15: Fracturing the unity between two siblings (family)
- Genesis 4:16-25: Fracturing the unity of a city (community)
- Genesis 6:1-4: Distorting the unity of Heaven and Earth (cosmos)
- Genesis 9:18-27: Fracturing the unity of the extended family (tribes)
- Genesis 11: Distorting the unity of the human family (nations)

To repair these layered distortions of the ideal unified humanity, future narratives will explore how the fractured human family becomes one again through covenant commitment.

Why the Two-Step Solution—Animals First Then the Matching Human?

This scene first allows the human to come to their own awareness of the solitude. When God “brings” the animals to the human, we can infer that he observes that they come in pairs. The next repetition of this motif, when God brings the animals to Noah and the ark, emphasizes that animals come “two by two” (Gen. 6:19-20; 7:2-3).

“Despite God’s identification of man’s need, there is a delay in his provision: contrast the instantaneous fulfillment of the divine word in chapter 1. This hold-up creates suspense. It allows us to feel man’s loneliness. All the animals are brought before him, and we see him looking at each one in the hope it would make a suitable companion for man. Ber. Rab. 17:5 pictures the animals passing by in pairs and man commenting, ‘Everything has its partner but I have no partner.’ The pathos is heightened in the narrative’s emphasis on the fact that the animals, like man (v 7), are shaped from the land (v 19), and, like him, are ‘living creatures.’ Furthermore, the word for ‘animal’ and ‘living,’ *ḥayyāh*, anticipates ‘Eve,’ *ḥawwāh*. Though in Hebrew these creatures’ names sound so similar to Eve’s, they are not what man is looking for. Despite man’s superiority to the other creatures, demonstrated by his naming of them (to give a name to something is to assert authority over it; cf. 1:26, 28), no suitable helper is found. Once again the narrative is laying the ground for chap. 3, establishing man’s place in the world, a little lower than the angels and a little higher than the animals.”

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [*World Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15*](#). Thomas Nelson.

“[Some] commentators consider that this scene implies that the Lord God made, as it were, a number of unsuccessful attempts, by creating various kinds of creatures and by passing them in review before Adam, to see if the man would find in one of them a helper corresponding to him; but it was all in vain, for not one of them satisfied him. This interpretation is unacceptable for the following reasons: 1) It would be strange to declare that God did not understand, so to speak, what man understood, that among the animals there was none ... corresponding to him ... it is [also] inconceivable that the experiment was carried out with all the beasts of the field and all the flying creatures of the air without exception, that is, even with creatures that were most unlike man. 2) It is explicitly written in v. 20 that the purpose of the Lord God in bringing the creatures before man, was only to see what he would call each one. It would seem that the text intends to tell us only that the Lord God wished to engender in the heart of man a desire for a helper who should correspond to him exactly. When the man would inspect all the species of animals in turn, and would find that some of them were indeed suited to serve him and help him to some extent, but yet there was not one among them that was his like *keneghdō*, he would become conscious of his loneliness and would yearn for one who could be his true companion ... in the full sense of the words, and, in consequence, he would be ready to appreciate and cherish the gift that the Lord God was to give him.”

Cassuto, Umberto (1961). [*A Commentary on the Book of Genesis: Part I, From Adam to Noah*](#). Hebrew University Magnes Press.

The Naming of the Animals in Genesis 2:19-20

In Genesis 1:1-2:3, God’s creative activity involves naming entities, that is, separating them out and conferring upon them a distinct identity and purpose. Here, God invites the human to imitate the divine creative act by naming the animals.

The portrait of God in this scene is of a creator who wants to share responsibility with his creation so that it can become what it is made to be.

“This portrayal of God, the creator of heaven and earth, leading all the animals one by one, and then the woman, to a face-to-face meeting with the ‘*adam*’, is truly remarkable ... God the Creator places the divine self at the service of the ‘good’ of the human being ... God’s role is to place the various possibilities before the human, but it is the creature that is given freedom to decide. God so values human freedom that God

will take into account the free human response from within the creative process in shaping the future ... The human being's naming of each creature is meant to be parallel to the divine naming in Gen. 1:5-10. This act is not perfunctory, like labeling the cages of a zoo. Naming is a part of the creative process itself ... human decisions are shown to be important to the ongoing development of the created order."

Fretheim, Terence E. (2005). [*God and the World in the Old Testament: A Relational Theology of Creation*](#). Abingdon Press.

Reflection Question

Summarize how the two becoming one flesh in Genesis 2:24 is a picture of God's ultimate plan for humanity.